# Housing Rental Policies & Rent Growth Trends

## Chicago Metropolitan Area

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# Motivation

- Rents rose +21.9% from 2015 to 2024
- Post-pandemic surge: +12.1% in just 4 years (2019–2023)
- 83% of Cook County census tracts have majority cost-burdened renters
- Cost burden = spending >30% of income on rent (HUD threshold)

> "A majority of Chicago renters spend more than 30% of their income on housing, but the crisis is not spread evenly across the city."

# Research Questions

## 01

### Temporal Dynamics

How have rents evolved across Chicago ZIP codes from 2015 to 2026, and how did COVID-19 policy shape that trajectory?

## 02

### Spatial Inequality

Which census tracts bear the highest rent burdens, and is geographic clustering visible?

## 03

### Policy Relevance

Do rent trends and burden concentrations align with key Chicago housing policy events?

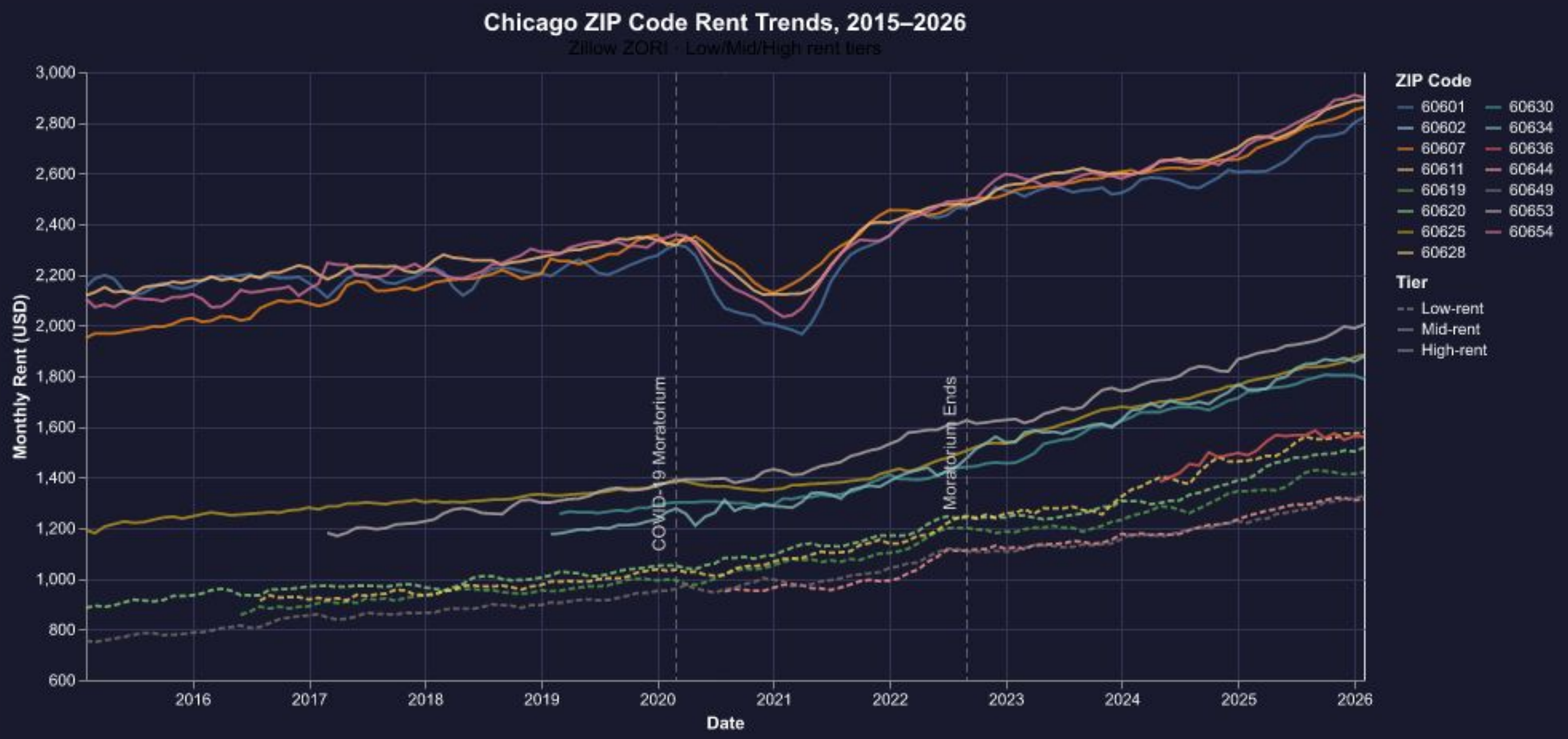
# Data Sources

Two independent datasets merged by geography

| Dataset | Source | Unit | Coverage |
| --- | --- | --- | --- |
| ACS B25064 – Median Gross Rent | U.S. Census Bureau | Census tract | 1,254 Cook County tracts |
| ACS B19013 – Median Household Income | U.S. Census Bureau | Census tract | 1,254 Cook County tracts |
| ACS B25070 – Rent Burden Bins | U.S. Census Bureau | Census tract | 1,254 Cook County tracts |
| Zillow ZORI – Monthly Rent Index | Zillow Research | ZIP code | 206 Chicago metro ZIPs · 2015–2026 |

# Finding 1: Rent Trends Over Time (2015–2026)

Zillow ZORI · 15 Chicago ZIP codes across Low / Mid / High rent tiers



# Finding 1: Key Takeaways

**Before COVID (2015–2019)**

- Modest growth: +3.2% over 4 years
- Market broadly stable across tiers

**COVID Period (2020–2021)**

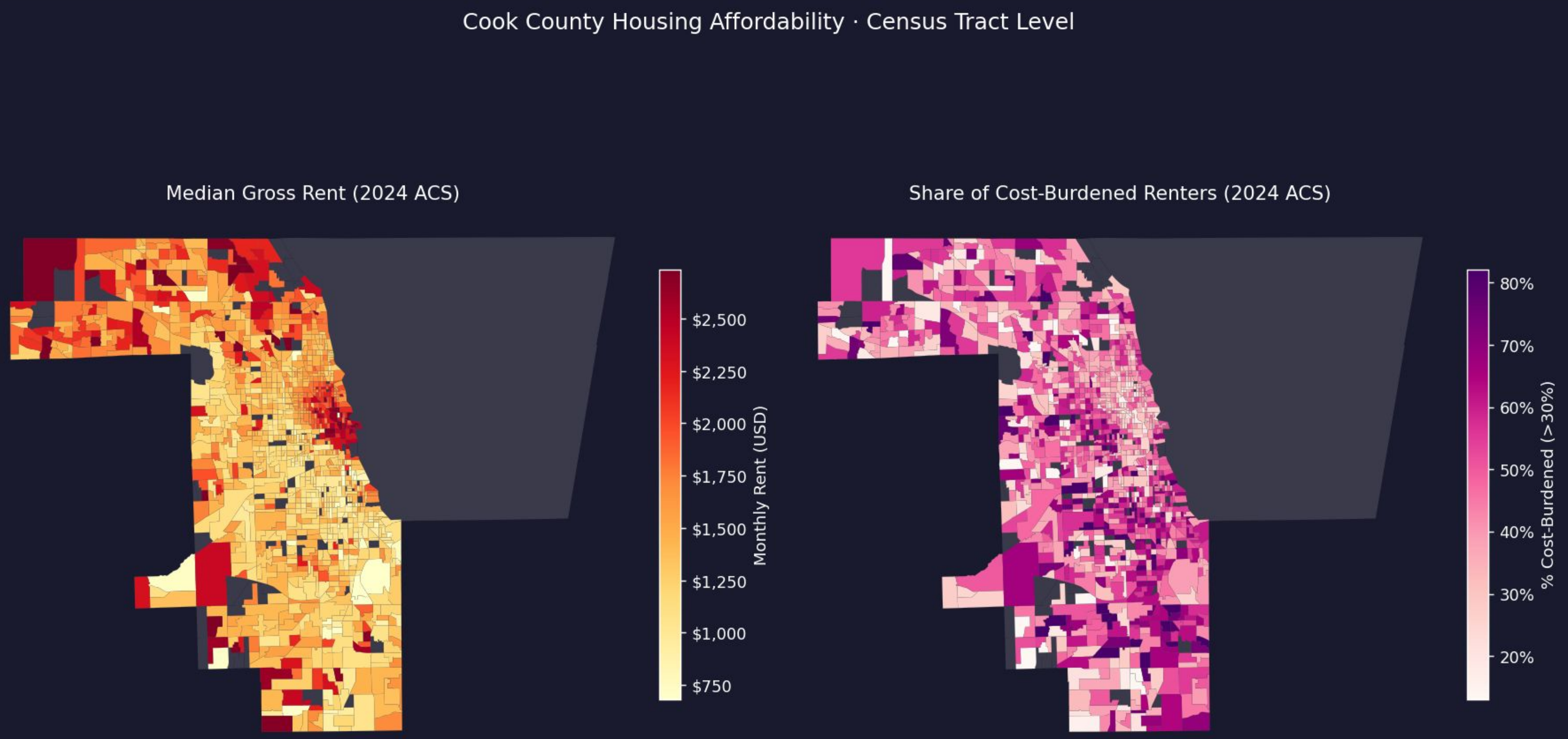
- Rents dipped: $1,532 → $1,521
- Eviction moratorium suppressed re-pricing

**Post-Moratorium Surge (2022–2024)**

- 2023 average: $1,728 (+12.1% vs 2019)
- 2024 average: $1,820 (+21.9% vs 2015)
- High-rent ZIPs recovered faster
- Intra-city rent gap widened

# Finding 2: Geographic Inequality

Cook County census tracts · 2024 ACS · Left: median rent | Right: % cost-burdened



# Finding 2: Key Takeaways

## Rent Level (left map)

• High rents cluster in Near North Side, Lincoln Park, Lakeview (>$2,000/mo)

• South & West Side tracts often below $900/mo

• Clear North–South gradient

## Cost Burden (right map)

• Severe burden ≠ highest-rent areas

• Concentrated in South/West Side (Englewood, Austin, Garfield Park)

• 40.7% of tracts: majority of renters are cost-burdened

• Driven by income inadequacy, not just high rents

**83.4%**

of tracts exceed
HUD 30% threshold

**40.7%**

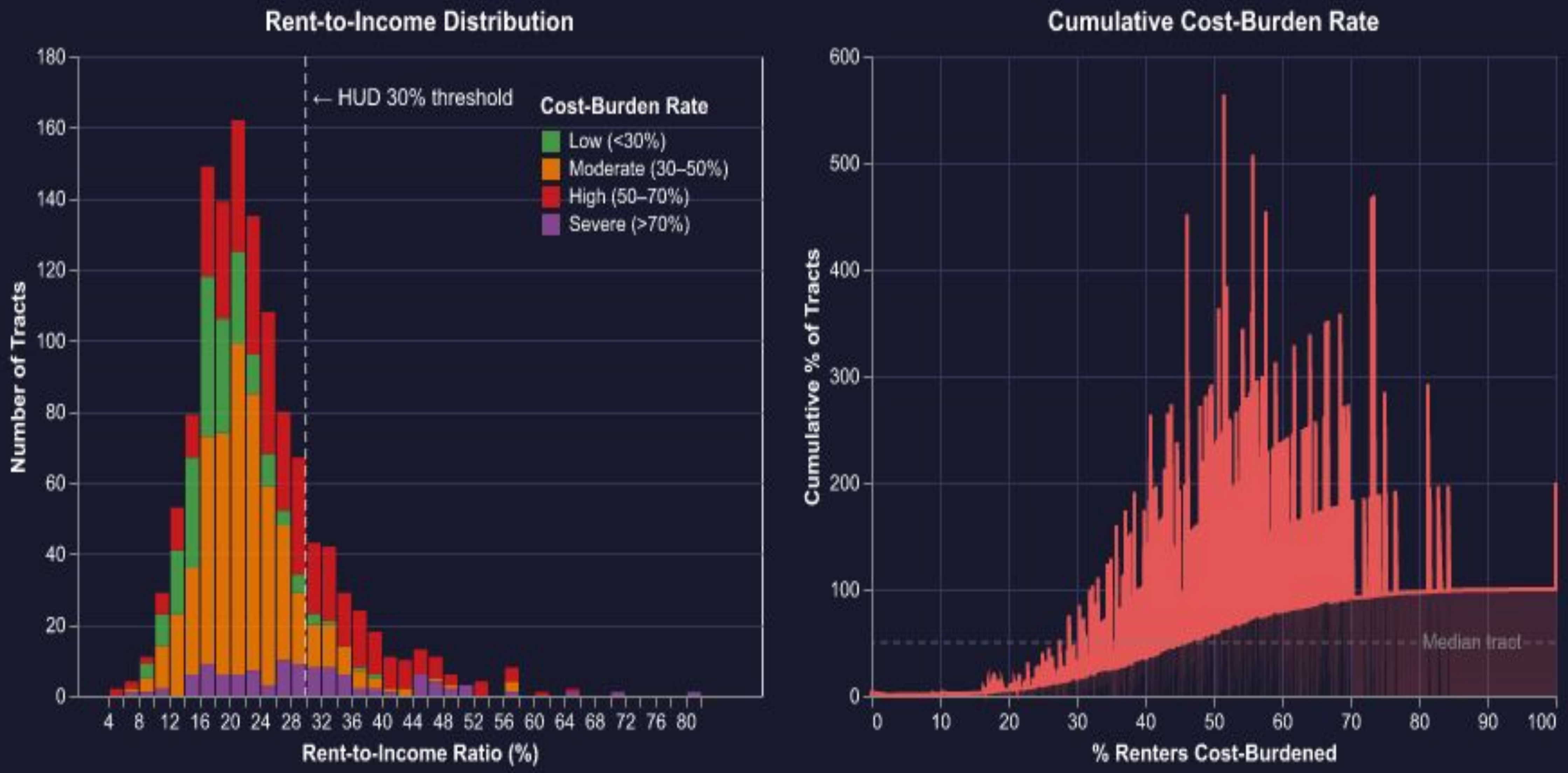
of tracts have >50%
renters burdened

**$1,100+**

median rent gap
North vs South Side

# Finding 3: Affordability Distribution

Cook County census tracts · 2024 ACS · Left: RTI histogram | Right: cumulative burden rate



# Finding 3: Key Takeaways

- Median rent-to-income ratio across Cook County: 21.9% — looks OK at the aggregate...
- But 83.4% of tracts have >30% of their renters cost-burdened
- 40.7% of tracts exceed the 50% threshold — the majority of renters in those tracts
- "Severe" tracts (>70% burdened) appear across the full RTI range: burden is driven by low income, not just high rent
- Only ~17% of tracts fall below the HUD affordability threshold

# Interactive Dashboard

Live Streamlit App — link: https://datavisualizationfinalproject-m7rnhvqfe9uemeai2vqwjt.streamlit.app/

### Tab 1
### Rent Trends

- Multi-select ZIP codes & cities
- Year range slider
- Policy event overlay toggle
- Summary stats table

### Tab 2
### Choropleth Map

- Switch: rent / RTI / burden rate
- Adjustable color scheme
- Top 10 burdened tracts table

### Tab 3
### Distribution

- RTI histogram (interactive)
- Cumulative burden ECDF
- Rent vs. burden scatter plot

⚠️ Remember to wake up the app the night before the presentation.

# Policy Implications

| Finding | Policy Recommendation |
|---|---|
| +12% rent surge after moratorium ends | Stronger tenant relocation assistance & just-cause eviction protections |
| Severe burden in South/West corridors | Target vouchers & affordable unit production to high-burden areas |
| 83% of tracts exceed HUD threshold | Expand rental assistance eligibility — current scale is insufficient |
| North Side rent appreciation gap | Anti-displacement zoning overlays in rapidly appreciating neighborhoods |

**Chicago's Affordable Requirements Ordinance (ARO) needs stronger income targeting and enforcement.**

# Conclusion

1. Rents rose 21.9% from 2015–2024, with the sharpest acceleration post-moratorium (2022–2024).

2. Geographic inequality is severe: high rents in the North, but the worst burden is concentrated in South/West Side neighborhoods due to low incomes.

3. Cost burden is the norm: 83% of Cook County tracts fail the HUD affordability standard — a systemic failure, not an isolated problem.

4. Both supply and income policies are needed: market-rate construction alone won't reach the communities that need help most.

# Thank You

Data: ACS 2024 · Zillow ZORI 2015–2026 · Census TIGER/Line 2024

Streamlit Dashboard: https://datavisualizationfinalproject-m7rnhvqfe9uemeai2vqwjt.streamlit.app/